Cuba, we had anticipated the possibility not of military action against Cuba on the part of the United States, but of a blockade of Cuba," recalled Mikoyan. "Proceeding from that, we anticipated that in case of such a turn of events we could obtain a resolution of the matter through the United Nations instead of resorting to military action."[15]

The question was what to do next. According to Mikoyan, Khrushchev immediately dictated the main points of the Soviet statement on the blockade. "The USSR gov't is appealing to the peoples of the USSR—and is informing them," reads the protocol of the meeting. "[Keep] working. [We are taking] measures so that we are not caught unawares." When Khrushchev finished dictating, it was long past 1:00 a.m. on October 23. They decided to take a break, get some sleep, and reconvene in the morning to discuss further steps. Sleep meant snoozing on the couches in their offices. Khrushchev did not undress. He wanted to be fully ready in case unexpected news reached the Kremlin. "I was ready for alarming news to come at any moment, and I wanted to be ready to react immediately," he recalled later. Khrushchev did not want to be caught with his pants down in the middle of a major crisis, as he believed had happened to the French foreign minister during the Suez Crisis.[16]

According to Mikoyan, they planned to reassemble at 8:00 a.m. on October 23, but the meeting was moved to 10:00 a.m. They focused on the discussion of the statements, letters, and communications they had to issue. The idea of giving General Pliev authority to use tactical nuclear weapons was now abandoned. The order that Marshal Malinovsky had sent to Cuba at 11:30 p.m. the previous evening remained in force. It read: "In connection with the possible landing of Americans participating in the maneuvers in the Caribbean Sea on Cuba, undertake urgent measures to increase combat readiness, and to repel the enemy by joint efforts of the Cuban army and all units of the Soviet troops, excluding the weapons of Statsenko's and of all Beloborodov's cargo."[17]

"Beloborodov's cargo" meant the nuclear warheads for both strategic and tactical missiles, which had been delivered to Cuba on the same ship, *Indigirka*, and remained in the custody of Colonel Nikolai Beloborodov. The directive prevented Pliev from using any nuclear weapons whatever. The alternative one, which gave him that right, and which Malinovsky